

BLASTER, MASTER India head coach Rahul Dravid gave every player the liberty to play his own game

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of the T20 World Cup exactly a year ago—India, playing outdated cricket, looked like a team burdened by the fear of failure. That's when skipper Rohit Sharma seemed to have drawn a line in the sand.

The rapid changes were evident. At India's press conferences, words like 'process', 'intent' and 'don't-think-about-the-result' formed a major part of the Indian skipper's vocabulary. At first, it seemed like lip service, especially since the press had been fed on a healthy diet of 'process' and 'intent', with no visible difference in India's approach or playing style for years. Then, it began to show. The blueprint became evident in the way India played each game. Every member of the playing XI played his part in the script. The idea was that if individual roles are performed to the T, the result would automatically take care of itself. Effectively, if the micro (your role) was taken care of, the macro (result) would follow.

The leader led from the front. Assigning himself the enforcer's role, Rohit would attack the bowlers from the get-go. Whether India were batting first or chasing, whether it was a belter of a pitch or a difficult one, the skipper, without fail, would throw down the gauntlet, batting averages be damned. All this while also allowing his opening partner, Shubman Gill, to play at the pace that he found comfortable.

Virat Kohli was given the role of being the glue that bound the team. As the world was busy celebrating his three hundreds in the tournament—an effort that took him past Sachin Tendulkar's record for the most ODI centuries—what went largely unnoticed were his two crucial, match-winning knocks versus Australia and New Zealand in the group stages. Neither were hundreds, but they showed that if the enforcer and his crew stuttered at the start, Kohli would steady the ship and help the team cross the finish line. And if anyone raised fingers at his circumspection as he neared a hundred, there's enough video evidence now to suggest that Kohli, the anchor, kept his run rate in sync with exactly what the team management wanted.

Then the middle order of Shreyas Iyer and K.L. Rahul was tasked with the role of operating at speeds in line with the condition or situation, or sometimes both. As was evident in some of the knocks they played. Iyer's 53 vs Pakistan at a strike rate of 85 was no less impactful than his 105 in the semis vs New Zealand at a strike rate of 150. Ditto for Rahul. His 97 vs Australia in the league stage at a conservative strike rate of 84 and 39 at a whopping rate of 195 vs New Zealand in the semis were both crucial. A case of the engine room effortlessly changing gears whilst driving the team to victory.

The final piece was Surya Kumar Yadav. Not expected to bat before the 35th over, the 'x' factor's role was to provide the final flourish. As he did in Lucknow vs England, with a 49 off 47 on a sluggish surface. The batting puzzle complete, the plan seemed to be working. Until it all went down. In the finals, no less.

HUNTER BECAME THE HUNTED

As the Indian juggernaut rolled on, on the back of its meticulous game plans, it also invited scrutiny from the rest of the cricketing world. The sameness in India's batting approach—fuelled by the unprecedented success that didn't necessitate any experiments—left them exposed. And, as the final showed, Australia didn't need a second invitation.